ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Advanced quantifiers and determiners

Control few, a few, little, a little, each, every, either, neither and quantifier agreement to express precise scope. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use advanced quantifiers and determiners to show amount, distribution and speaker evaluation without creating agreement errors while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Control few, a few, little, a little, each, every, either, neither and quantifier agreement to express precise scope.

MODEL

Few applicants met every requirement, but a few showed strong potential.

quantifier + count/non-count noun | distributive determiner + singular noun

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main advanced quantifiers and determiners patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses show amount, distribution and speaker evaluation without creating agreement errors.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in reports, comparisons, instructions and everyday discussion.

Build meaning before form

Control few, a few, little, a little, each, every, either, neither and quantifier agreement to express precise scope.

What advanced quantifiers and determiners communicates

Control few, a few, little, a little, each, every, either, neither and quantifier agreement to express precise scope.

The central purpose is to show amount, distribution and speaker evaluation without creating agreement errors. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

Few applicants met every requirement.	a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing
A few candidates showed exceptional potential.	a small but useful or positive amount
Each participant received a separate access code.	individual distribution across members of a set

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: quantifier + count/non-count noun | distributive determiner + singular noun. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “Few applicants met every requirement, but a few showed strong potential.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Negative quantity	few/little + noun	Few applicants met every requirement.
Positive small amount	a few/a little + noun	A few candidates showed exceptional potential.
Distribution	each/every/either/neither + singular noun	Each participant received a separate access code.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing	Negative quantity
a small but useful or positive amount	Positive small amount
individual distribution across members of a set	Distribution

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in reports, comparisons, instructions and everyday discussion. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04
quantifier	count/non-count noun	distributive determiner	singular noun

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: show amount, distribution and speaker evaluation without creating agreement errors.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits reports, comparisons, instructions and everyday discussion.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Negative quantity	few/little + noun	Few applicants met every requirement.
Positive small amount	a few/a little + noun	A few candidates showed exceptional potential.
Distribution	each/every/either/neither + singular noun	Each participant received a separate access code.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

Few applicants met every requirement.	a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing
A few candidates showed exceptional potential.	a small but useful or positive amount
Each participant received a separate access code.	individual distribution across members of a set

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use few with uncountable nouns or little with plural count nouns.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not remove the article when the intended evaluation is positive.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use a plural noun directly after each or every.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing?

OPTIONS Few applicants met every requirement. · A few candidates showed exceptional potential. · Each participant received a separate access code.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a small but useful or positive amount?

OPTIONS A few candidates showed exceptional potential. · Each participant received a separate access code. · Few applicants met every requirement.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: individual distribution across members of a set?

OPTIONS Each participant received a separate access code. · Few applicants met every requirement. · A few candidates showed exceptional potential.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “Few applicants met every requirement.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing · a small but useful or positive amount · individual distribution across members of a set

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “A few candidates showed exceptional potential.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a small but useful or positive amount · individual distribution across members of a set · a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Each participant received a separate access code.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS individual distribution across members of a set · a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing · a small but useful or positive amount

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"Few applicants met every requirement." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Negative quantity / Positive small amount / Distribution · Gap 2: a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing / a small but useful or positive amount / individual distribution across members of a set

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"A few candidates showed exceptional potential." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Positive small amount / Distribution / Negative quantity · Gap 2: a small but useful or positive amount / individual distribution across members of a set / a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"Each participant received a separate access code." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Distribution / Negative quantity / Positive small amount · Gap 2: individual distribution across members of a set / a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing / a small but useful or positive amount

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing: _____. Choose the model that expresses a small but useful or positive amount: _____. Choose the model that expresses individual distribution across members of a set: _____. Choose the model built with few/little + noun: _____. Choose the model built with a few/a little + noun: _____. Choose the model built with each/every/either/neither + singular noun: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A few candidates showed exceptional potential. · Each participant received a separate access code. · Few applicants met every requirement.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____ met every requirement. _____ showed exceptional potential. _____ received a separate access code. State the full structural pattern for Negative quantity: _____. State the full structural pattern for Positive small amount: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “Only a disappointing number met all requirements.” using the Negative quantity pattern to express a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Some candidates provided a positive result.” using the Positive small amount pattern to express a small but useful or positive amount.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Codes were distributed individually to all participants.” using the Distribution pattern to express individual distribution across members of a set.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “Only a disappointing number met all requirements.” using the Negative quantity pattern to express a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Negative quantity to express a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Positive small amount to express a small but useful or positive amount, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Distribution to express individual distribution across members of a set, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

Few applicants met every requirement.

Negative quantity is the best match because a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing.

A2

A few candidates showed exceptional potential.

Positive small amount is the best match because a small but useful or positive amount.

A3

Each participant received a separate access code.

Distribution is the best match because individual distribution across members of a set.

A4

a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing

The Negative quantity pattern communicates a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing.

A5

a small but useful or positive amount

The Positive small amount pattern communicates a small but useful or positive amount.

A6

individual distribution across members of a set

The Distribution pattern communicates individual distribution across members of a set.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Negative quantity / a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing

The structure belongs to the Negative quantity pattern. Its communicative purpose is a small amount presented as insufficient or disappointing.

B2

Positive small amount / a small but useful or positive amount

The structure belongs to the Positive small amount pattern. Its communicative purpose is a small but useful or positive amount.

B3

Distribution / individual distribution across members of a set

The structure belongs to the Distribution pattern. Its communicative purpose is individual distribution across members of a set.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

Few applicants met every requirement.

Negative quantity: few/little + noun.

C2

A few candidates showed exceptional potential.

Positive small amount: a few/a little + noun.

C3

Each participant received a separate access code.

Distribution: each/every/either/neither + singular noun.

C4

Few applicants met every requirement.

Negative quantity: few/little + noun.

C5

A few candidates showed exceptional potential.

Positive small amount: a few/a little + noun.

C6

Each participant received a separate access code.

Distribution: each/every/either/neither + singular noun.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

Few applicants

Negative quantity requires “Few applicants” in this model. few/little + noun.

D2

A few candidates

Positive small amount requires “A few candidates” in this model. a few/a little + noun.

D3

Each participant

Distribution requires “Each participant” in this model. each/every/either/neither + singular noun.

D4

few/little + noun

Negative quantity is built as few/little + noun.

D5

a few/a little + noun

Positive small amount is built as a few/a little + noun.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

Few applicants met every requirement.

few/little + noun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended negative quantity effect.

E2

A few candidates showed exceptional potential.

a few/a little + noun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended positive small amount effect.

E3

Each participant received a separate access code.

each/every/either/neither + singular noun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended distribution effect.

E4

Few applicants met every requirement.

few/little + noun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended negative quantity effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

Few applicants met every requirement. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses few/little + noun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

A few candidates showed exceptional potential. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses a few/a little + noun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Each participant received a separate access code. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses each/every/either/neither + singular noun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____